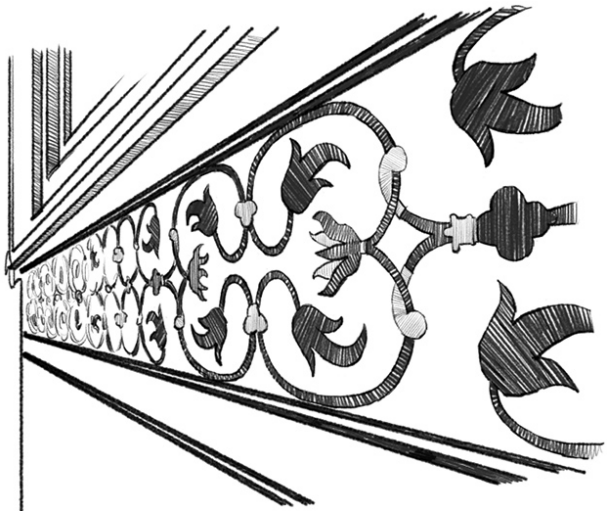
CHAPTER 7
Jewels and More Jewels

The twelfth Urs took place when Mumtaz's tomb was completed. That was in 1643. It was already a beautiful sight. But Shah Jahan was not satisfied. He wanted it to be even more spectacular. It had to be decorated the way he imagined Heaven to look.

Shah Jahan loved jewelry of all kinds. He designed jewelry himself, and paintings show him wearing it on his body and his turban. He used a string of perfect pearls as prayer beads.

He wanted the walls of the Taj Mahal to shine with jewels. Throughout the building are precious and semi-precious stones.



The most common designs are flowers that are made of tiny jewels. Shah Jahan's favorite flower was a tulip, and there are many of them on the walls.

A craftsman would use a grinding wheel to make an outline of the flower in the marble. Then he cut pieces of gems to fit into the space perfectly. A kind of glue was used to hold the pieces in place. The surface of the flower was polished so that the lines between pieces became invisible. Some of the jeweled tulips are amazingly detailed. As many as sixty pieces of stone are used to make a flower only one inch high.